LEE GRAHAM (NMI)

World War II Service & Family Research Notes

487th Bomb Group • 837th Bomb Squadron • Eighth Air Force

Prepared for family preservation • October 1, 2026

Purpose of this file
This is a living family-research file. It separates documented facts, strong archival leads, family oral history, and working estimates so that the stories are preserved without turning uncertainty into fact.

Research status key

CONFIRMED	Supported by a named archival or unit-history source.
STRONG LEAD	Evidence is specific and credible, but an additional primary record would strengthen it.
FAMILY HISTORY	A recollection passed down in the family; preserved here as told, not presented as proven.
WORKING ESTIMATE	A reasoned estimate with substantial uncertainty; not a historical fact.

1. What is confirmed so far

Lee Graham was born August 13, 1922, and died July 6, 1995. Online genealogical records place him in Adamsville, Jefferson County, Alabama. Joe has confirmed that this is his grandfather.

- Military role: Corporal, tail gunner.
- Unit: 837th Bomb Squadron, 487th Bomb Group (Heavy), U.S. Army Air Forces, Eighth Air Force.
- Base in England: Station 137, RAF Lavenham, Suffolk.
- Aircraft association: B-24H Liberator serial 42-52748, “Old Gray Gull” / “Old Grey Gull.”
- The 837th Bomb Squadron used fuselage code 4F; Old Grey Gull is identified in surviving aircraft-photo records as 4F-N while with the 487th.

The strongest individual record found is the Imperial War Museums / American Air Museum “American Archive” entry for Lee Graham. Lee Graham – American Archive It identifies him as an American corporal and tail gunner, lists B-24 42-52748 Old Gray Gull, and connects him to both the 487th Bomb Group and 837th Bomb Squadron. The entry states that its sources were the National Museum of the Mighty Eighth Air Force and the 487th Bomb Group roster.

2. The unit and the aircraft

The 487th Bomb Group arrived at Lavenham equipped with B-24 Liberators and began combat operations in May 1944. The group was pulled from combat on July 19, 1944, to convert to the B-17 Flying Fortress; the 837th completed the transition on August 1, 1944. 487th Bomb Group history at Lavenham Airfield 837th Bomb Squadron history

That matters because Lee's family remembered him as a B-17 gunner, while the surviving personal record ties him to a B-24. Both can be true: his squadron flew B-24s first and B-17s afterward.

Old Grey Gull was B-24H-15-FO serial 42-52748. Surviving B-24 photo-reference pages identify it as an Eighth Air Force / 487th Bomb Group / 837th Bomb Squadron aircraft, code 4F-N. The aircraft was later transferred to the 450th Bomb Group in the Fifteenth Air Force. Sources agree on the transfer but differ on the exact date of its later crash landing in Italy, so that detail remains open for verification.

3. Photographs and visual leads

At least three online image-reference pages exist for Old Grey Gull. These are photographs of the aircraft, not yet confirmed photographs of Lee himself:

- Old Grey Gull – Photo 1
- Old Grey Gull – Photo 2
- Old Grey Gull – Photo 3

The 487th Bomb Group Association roster is especially important because its roster pages explicitly include links to individual portraits, crew photographs, and aircraft photographs where available. 487th Bomb Group roster

4. Family oral history to preserve

Story 1 – The nose gunner survived

As remembered by Joe from his father: on one bombing run the crew encountered flak and enemy fire. The nose gunner was hit or his position was badly damaged, and the crew believed he had been killed. When they returned to base, they discovered that he was still strapped in and alive even though the glass around his position was gone or shattered.

Research note: This story is mechanically plausible for a B-24H. That model introduced an Emerson A-15 powered nose turret, making "nose gunner" a natural description. The later B-17G also had heavy forward armament, though its chin turret was normally controlled from the bombardier/navigator area. The specific incident has not yet been matched to a mission report or crew narrative.

Story 2 – Throwing equipment overboard to make England

As remembered by Joe from his father: on another return flight the aircraft was dangerously low on fuel. The crew threw out anything that was not bolted down while crossing the English Channel in an effort to reduce weight and get home.

Research note: Fuel emergencies were a real and recurring hazard for 487th Bomb Group crews. Group histories document aircraft diverting, landing with engines quitting from fuel starvation, and in at least one case a 487th B-24 being lost in the Channel after running out of fuel. None of those examples has yet been tied to Lee, so this family story remains unverified but historically plausible.

5. Scale of the 487th Bomb Group's combat

Group statistic	Recorded figure
Combat missions	185
Credited sorties	6,021
Bomb tonnage	about 14,000–14,600 tons (sources vary by accounting method)
Enemy aircraft claims	22 destroyed, 6 probable, 18 damaged
487th aircrew killed	233 names commemorated at Lavenham

The group-level numbers give context, but they cannot by themselves tell us exactly what Lee's individual crew experienced. Reconstructing his mission list is the key next step.

6. Preliminary estimate of people killed by Lee's crew

> **WORKING ESTIMATE — LOW CONFIDENCE**
> The best current order-of-magnitude estimate is that the crew may have caused roughly single-digit to low-teen deaths over a full combat tour, mostly through bombing rather than defensive gunfire. A much wider range — from zero to several dozen — remains plausible. This is not a historical finding; it is a statistical placeholder until Lee's actual missions and targets are identified.

Defensive guns: No source found so far credits Lee personally with shooting down an enemy aircraft. The entire 487th Bomb Group claimed 22 enemy aircraft destroyed across 6,021 credited sorties. Until a combat claim or mission report names Lee or his crew, his confirmed aerial-kill count should be treated as zero confirmed, not necessarily zero actual.

Bombing casualties: Attributing casualties to a single bomber is inherently difficult. Aircraft usually bombed in formation, many targets were military or transportation targets, and casualty totals were often recorded at the raid or city level rather than by individual airplane. The U.S. Strategic Bombing Survey estimated at least 305,000 people killed by Allied bombing in Germany, but applying that broad figure directly to one aircraft would create false precision. The mission-by-mission route is far more defensible.

7. Best next research steps

- Reconstruct Lee Graham's exact mission dates, aircraft assignments, and crew positions from 487th Bomb Group loading lists, special orders, morning reports, and mission records.
- Identify the pilot/crew under whom Lee normally flew. Crew photographs and narratives are often indexed under the pilot rather than the gunner.
- Search the 487th photo archive and National Museum of the Mighty Eighth Air Force holdings for Lee Graham, Old Grey Gull, serial 42-52748, and the eventual pilot/crew name.
- Compare the two family stories against mission reports for battle damage, wounded crew, emergency landings, fuel shortages, and jettisoned equipment.
- Once the mission list is known, examine target-specific after-action reports and local casualty records before revising the casualty estimate.

8. Sources saved with this research

- Lee Graham – American Archive (Imperial War Museums / American Air Museum)
- 487th Bomb Group Association roster
- 487th Bomb Group aircraft roster
- 487th Bomb Group history – Lavenham Airfield
- 487th mission log – all 185 missions
- 487th Bomb Group – 8th Air Force history
- Old Grey Gull photo 1 – B-24 Best Web
- Old Grey Gull photo 3 – B-24 Best Web
- 450th Bomb Group aircraft list – later Old Grey Gull service
- U.S. Strategic Bombing Survey – Summary Report (European War)
- Lee Graham 1922–1995 – Adamsville, Alabama genealogical listing

Family note

The two combat stories above were preserved from Joe's memory of hearing his father tell them years after Lee Graham's death. They are included because oral history is evidence of what a family remembered, even when documentation has not yet caught up with the story.